

Block 4 — Life Span: Adulthood & Ageing (20–65+)

Early Adulthood (20–40)

Cognitive Changes 10M

Schaie's stages: Achieving (applying intelligence to long-term goals) → **Responsibility** (family, career, community).

Perry's reflective/relativistic thinking: Dualistic → Multiple → Relative subordinate → **Full relativism**.

Post-formal thought: correct answer varies by situation; emotion influences thinking.

Labouvie-Vief: idealised logic replaced with commitment.

Erikson: Intimacy vs. Isolation 6M

Intimacy requires redefining identity to include another. Cooperative, tolerant, accepting. Too much isolation → competitive, threatened. Successful → generativity.

Levinson's Life Structure 6M

Life structure: underlying design (relationships + occupations). **Dream:** image of self in adult world. **Age-30 transition:** reevaluate. **Social clock:** age-graded expectations. Feminine (marriage/20s) vs. Masculine (career) social clock.

Sternberg's Triangular Theory of Love 6M

3 components: **Intimacy** (warmth) · **Passion** (arousal) · **Commitment**.

Passionate love (beginnings) → **Companionate love** (intimacy + commitment).

Communication requires warmth, forgiveness, sensitivity, acceptance, respect.

Attachment Patterns 3M

Internal working model predicts adult romantic relationships.

Secure (likable, open, trusting) · **Avoidant** (independent, mistrusting, emotional distance) ·

Resistant/anxious-ambivalent (fears abandonment, smothering).

Middle Adulthood (40–60) 10M

Erikson: Generativity vs. Stagnation

Generativity = expand influence, commitment to family/society/future generations. Mentoring, volunteering, parenting. Stagnation = self-absorption.

Levinson's Four Tasks

(1) **Young-Old:** give up youthful qualities. (2) **Destruction-Creation:** re-evaluate past hurtful acts. (3) **Masculinity-Femininity:** integrate masculine/feminine aspects. (4) **Engagement-Separateness:** balance outer engagement with interior needs.

Intelligence

Crystallized (Horn & Hofer, 1992): verbal reasoning, vocabulary — improves through middle age.

Fluid: flexible reasoning, speed — peaks early adulthood, declines. Best works: mathematicians/scientists (20s–30s) vs. historians/philosophers (40s–50s).

Sternberg's triarchic: Analytic (efficient learning) · Creative (flexibility, expertise) · Practical (adapting to context).

Memory/processing decline. Strategies decrease decline.

Relationships

Launching children (no longer negative). **U-curve** marital satisfaction. **Feminisation of poverty.** Grandparenthood. Siblings: sister closer. Friends: quality > quantity. **Androgyny.**

Late Adulthood (65+) 6M

Physical Changes

Primary ageing (biological) vs. **Secondary ageing** (hereditary/environment).

Hair gray/thin · Skin wrinkled · **Presbyopia** · Hearing loss (~30% over 60) · Decreased taste/smell/touch.

Young-old vs. **Old-old**.

Cognitive Changes

Response speeds decline. Working memory decreases.

Selective optimisation with compensation — narrow goals, maximise returns, compensate for losses.

Terminal decline — steady cognitive decrease before death.

Memory

Slower processing · Less use of strategies · Recognition > free recall · **Implicit memory** more intact than deliberate · **Autobiographical memory** best recall of adolescence/early adulthood · **Prospective memory** declines.

Wisdom

Practical knowledge, emotional maturity, listening skills, creativity helping others. Increases with age. Components: knowledge about life, effective strategies, concern for common good, awareness of uncertainties.

Schaie & Willis: decline reversed in 40–60% of elderly with training.

Erikson: Ego Integrity vs. Despair 6M

Integrity = whole, satisfied with life. Despair = bitterness, anxiety about death.

Peck's Three Tasks

(1) **Ego differentiation vs. work-role preoccupation** — self-worth beyond career.

(2) **Body transcendence vs. body preoccupation** — value beyond physical.

(3) **Ego transcendence vs. ego preoccupation** — facing death constructively.

Labouvie-Vief: Emotional Expertise

Elders more in touch with feelings. Better **emotional self-regulation**. Younger people more impulsively emotional.

Reminiscence & Life Review

Reminiscence: telling stories about past. **Life review:** reflecting on meaning → greater self-understanding.

Relationships in Late Life

Social convoy: family + friends providing safety/support. Marriage: satisfaction rises if fairness increases. Siblings: sister bonds closer. Friends: offer intimacy, companionship, link to community.

Psychosocial Changes Summary

Secure/multifaceted self-concept · Agreeableness higher · Sociability drops (selective) · Acceptance of change · Spirituality/religiosity advances · Dependency-support vs. independence-ignore scripts.